

Management & Leadership Exploration/Analysis

Leading & Managing Information Organizations
INFO 507
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02/02/25

Organization Information

The Free Library of Philadelphia, originally chartered in 1891 and opened in 1894, was a project initiated by Dr. William Pepper that aimed to be “a general library which shall be to all”. Bouncing around from various locations, the central library building opening its premises on Logan Square in 1927. Various neighborhood libraries have been added throughout the years, many funded by Andrew Carnegie who is known for donating large swaths of money to open public libraries in various communities in the United States (*History of the Library*, n.d.). Today, the Free Library’s system is composed of Parkway Central Library, three large regional libraries, 49 neighborhood libraries, community Hot Spots, the Library for the Blind and Physically Handicapped, the Regional Research and Operations Center, and the Rosenbach. Ranking up within the top 20 largest library systems in the country, the Free Library’s mission is “to advance literacy, guide learning, and inspire curiosity. Its vision is to build an enlightened community devoted to lifelong learning” (*About the Library*, n.d.). The Free Library of Philadelphia is a public non-profit library, with its funding allocated by the city council. Through the past century, the Free Library has become a central staple to the Philadelphia landscape.

Organizational Structure

The Free Library is currently in a time of transition, a point which can be noted with its ongoing transformation of a strategic plan. The last time the library published a strategic plan strategy was for the years of 2018 – 2020, with the main goals of the library including: building a culture of literacy in Philadelphia, deliver an exceptional customer experience, embrace creativity and innovation (*Application for Paschalvill Partnership*, n.d.). In the past year, however, the Free Library has put out calls for collaboration from the community to work on a “Strategic Planning Initiative”. With aims to “foster transparency, accountability, accessibility, and be fully participatory”, the library is aiding this initiative with questions concerning how the pandemic changed the library, how business and service structures can create a more responsive library system, and how the Free Library of Philadelphia Foundation can also expand its portfolio (*Charting Our Future Together*, n.d.). To lead the library towards these goals, there is a robust executive staff with a formal organizational structure. At the very top is the Board of Trustees, followed by the current President and Director, then six directors directly under the president, and finally, eight various chiefs that lead different divisions of the Free Library (Appendix A). There is division between those who oversee the central library versus the neighborhood libraries. Another division in the staffing concerns the Library of Accessible Media for Pennsylvanians (LAMP), which is a state-run program that falls under the jurisdiction of the Free Library. The section of the library does not just serve people who live in Philadelphia, but serves the entire state (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025).

Each chief oversees various levels of staff, a system which also has variety between the different divisions. There are assistant chiefs, two levels of supervisors, and entry level librarians. Lowest on the totem pole include non-professional staff such as library assistants. Historically, to be apart of the executive staff, one would have to start as an entry level library (Librarian I) and slowly work through the ranks, climbing as their career progressed. During the COVID 19 pandemic there was a large leadership change throughout the executive staff of the Free Library. The Director of the Free Library resigned amid the Black Lives Matter Protests as they were under significant criticism and the

confidence of the mayor and the city council was lost. At the same time, various people who were nearing the end of their careers used the pandemic as a reason to officially retire. This meant that there was a large reshuffling of people throughout the leadership of the Free Library. The new director not only promoted those already working within the Free Library, but also brought in some outside people who have not worked with the system before (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025).

Organizational Culture

The organizational culture at the Free Library of Philadelphia has changed throughout the years. With the new director and various people reshuffled to different positions, there was a fresh wave of many fresh perspectives within the organization. The new staff members really emphasized one large point: transparent communication. This can be noted in the calls for developing a new strategic plan, which also calls for more transparency within the planning (*Charting Our Future Together*, n.d.). The library has also obtained a much larger funding in comparison to pre-pandemic numbers. Today, the budget is about three times the size as it was. The Free Library was so underfunded that it had to get a waiver from the state to operate as they had to provide a certain level of service. This can be seen clearly in public records. Records were found from 2019 and 2023 budgets. In 2019, the total budget was a little over 17 million and by 2023 that budget is now 55 million, a difference of over 3 times the amount (*City of Philadelphia 2019 Operating Budget*, 2019; *City of Philadelphia Fiscal 2023 Operating Budget*, 2023). Obtaining a historically large budget for the library means that the library staff is able to take more risks and try new formats. For example, the Free Library recently was able to start circulating video games, something various libraries have been doing for a while. Previously, there had been a cultural perception throughout the library that people assumed that video games would be lost to theft and wouldn't be worthwhile overall. This, however, has not been the case, and video game rentals have been quite popular throughout the library. With a smaller budget, taking risks on new formats such as video games would likely not have happened (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025).

Being largely organized around branches that act as teams within the organization allow for a degree of easygoing, yet professional work culture to proliferate. As the Free Library is a public non-profit, there is not a large focus on numbers, metrics of quarterlies, or hitting a specific number of circulations. Where there is competitiveness, it is in comparison to other larger library systems in the country, a healthy competition between peers in order to deliver the best service to the community possible (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025). There is a general feeling that it is not very difficult for new employees to become acclimatized and thrive within the Free Library, but this might depend on the timing of being hired. Pre- and post-pandemic, it appears that the Free Library has a very positive work environment that is quite accepting of new people and really centrally focuses on growth. During the pandemic, large quantities of people were leaving the Free Library and there was a lot of shifting between jobs that felt uncertainty in almost every section of the job sector. This uncertainty was also absolutely felt within the Free Library, and many newer hires did not stay very long (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025).

It could be argued that the Free Library operates in a *placid-clustered* environment. This type of environment is characterized by long-term goals, but acknowledges that dangers arise in clusters. Evans & Greenwell (2020) argue that,

“Most educational institutions and public libraries operate in this type of environment. They set long-term goals and rarely change those goals, although they may change short-term objectives. However, they do recognize that dangers exist, such as changing public attitudes about the value of social services generally and library services specifically. Once the questioning starts, it generally expands in scope (a phenomenon known as “clustering”) and does not disappear quickly.”

Government and political change are highly important in discerning what sort of environment an institution is operating in, it can produce policies and regulations that change management of staff as well as potentials for additional funding (or funding taken away) (Evans & Greenwell, 2020).

Other factors that highly influence the organizational culture at the Free Library are both the union and a city-governed HR, both of which are very involved in the day-to-day operations at the Free Library, but are not technically governed by the library. First, the existence of the union is a large positive for the culture. There are notes that it slows down incidents in order to enforce more strict moderation, so that things are not drawn out of proportion too fast. The union also ensures that management stays within the boundaries of confines are not out of line. The Human Resources department is also a group within the library that is not maintained by the library. The City of Philadelphia manages the Human Resources, which then has a division that is involved with the Free Library. Whenever this is some sort of conflict or tricky disciplinary problem, both the union and HR get involved (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025). Having a dedicated HR can be good for organizational culture as it allows for an outside mediator.

Manager's Information

The manager interviewed for this report is named Jamie Wilson. He is the Chief, Materials Manager at the Free Library of Philadelphia and is apart of the executive staff, about two degrees away from the director. Jamie's primary responsibilities include supervising collection development, orders and acquisitions, and cataloging and processing. He oversees the processing of order books arriving and the physical handling of the materials before they get sent off to the various branches. Generally, he oversees the work of other people that are doing the hands-on work, and stated that he shouldn't be doing hands-on work. His main job now focuses with working on the vision and various strategies (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025). Jamie acted in this position as Chief Materials Manager for about a year and a half before officially taking the job, the result of people resigning mid-COVID 19 pandemic. The Materials Management Branch of the library is in charge of the selection of materials for the library. Books are the main format worked with, but this also includes DVDs and video games, and audio-books. There is a division within the library in regards to selection of books and ordering of books. Jamie explains that this is a safeguard to mitigate against potential ethical problems. He explains, “so that, for example, someone doesn't buy a thousand copies of their brother's book”. This brings two divisions within the branch: one group of people who are subject matter experts and designate what is needed, and another group of people who work with vendors to place orders (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025).

Jamie has been employed at the Free Library of Philadelphia for over twenty years, with a quite linear career path. Originally, he went to college with a double major in English and Anthropology, but wasn't happy with the jobs that he could find as he didn't want to be a teacher. Once presented with the

opportunity to go to grade school, he decided that he wanted a career path that was more direct as he didn't want to be in the same position that he was in as a result of his undergraduate degree. So he pursued a Masters in Library Science from Drexel University. After graduating with a masters, he was able to secure a job at the Free Library in the Central Branch. Jamie was placed there as he was living in Delaware and the management at the time was willing to accommodate his commute. While he was hired as an entry-level librarian (Library I), he notes that it was a very eye-opening experience. Jamie notes the types of customer service experience that he was expected to do, such as helping with peoples resumes and helping with other some basic tasks such as saving a document. Today, the library hires social workers that work at the library every to help with various tasks that he was expected to do. Afterwards, he became the electronic resource coordinator for the library, which meant evaluating databases and resources and recommending ones for purchase. Jamie noted that coordinators didn't supervise anyone and he realized that if he wanted to move up in the organization, he would have to gain management experience. So he applied and was promoted to becoming the head of the acquisitions unit. Afterwards, he became head of the collections development, which was supervising various libraries. Jamie stated,

"It seems like a lot but I've been here for a really long time. I've worked here since 2006. So it didn't feel fast. It felt like a normal kind of transitional period. And working for a public library, one of the challenges is that you're a city employee. So, you're a civil servant and that means hiring and the promotional process is very regimented and can take a very long time. It's this very long process and the way promotion generally works is you take a test and based on how well you do on the test, you get an interview and then they hire for the position, so it's very different from the private sector. It is usually from within or almost all promotion as from within. Most people who come here start as Library I and then work their way up. They sometimes have a job they can't fill or whatever reason, like people are not attracted to it, they'll hire from the outside but that's pretty rare" (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025).

Gathering from the interview, it seems that Jamie's career path is quite similar to those of his peers and other executives. The ways in which promotions are handled are to protect both the Free Library as well and the City of Philadelphia. It is important to make sure that these aspects are appropriate as if inexperienced people are put into jobs they cannot work, there is not a discussion sparked about inappropriate use of city funding and taxpayer dollars.

Manager's Style

It is quite clear that Jamie's management style has drastically evolved over the years. He never exactly went into library studies expecting to be a manager, but grew into the role and states that it was quite a natural process as he has learned a lot about the systems that are in place. He did note that he didn't feel like he had to strive a particularly large amount to move up, it just takes a while. He has a variety of people that relies on for advice throughout the library. One person in particular is his division assistant chief, a woman whom which he shared the current job with, 60 days on and 60 days off, for about a year before he finally accepted the role full time. According to Jamie, neither of them wanted the role and were content with their roles at the time. He explained, "She and I are really close so we

bounce ideas off each other all the time. And that's really great to have, it been really good to come into a situation where you're working in the same division, just cause I have good relationships with all the people who I work with". It seems to be a similar relationship between him and his manager, that it tends to be collaborative but there is also a large amount of trust involved. He also notes that having union protection can be really helpful for managing people and building relationships, because the ego needs to be negated to an extent as it's not easy to just fire people on a whim (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025).

As far as management style is concern, Jamie notes that he is very collaborative, more leaning to a humanizer style of management. Some of his goals are to take his own ego out of his management, find pragmatic ways to handle situations, and trust that the people who he's working with can do their job correctly. Regarding this process, he notes that often people just want feedback and they want someone to say that something works and is willing to take responsibility for it as well and potentially make some suggestions. He noted that he has also learned to be more careful over the years, which is the biggest way that his management style has evolved, as his decisions do have a lot of ripple effects and repercussions for other people. He has also observed other managers that are trying to do too much, creating a chaotic environment for those around him. But, at the end of the day, Jamie states that he doesn't want to be a scary boss, that he wants collegial relationships with his colleagues and he wants to recognize where his weaknesses are and strengthen them (W. Jamie, personal communication, January 22, 2025).

Evaluation of the Manager and the Information Organization

As has been previously discussed, the Free Library of Philadelphia is currently in a state of transition. With about triple the budget and a large exodus from previous executive staff when comparing the library currently to the pre-pandemic library, there is a new focus on redrafting mission statements and planning the future of the library in the city. Historically, the city has not always met the goals and objectives that they set out, particularly with their complacency in existing in a state of being perpetually underfunded. Ensuring that the Free Library of Philadelphia serves absolutely all types of people and is an equitable institution is vitally important, as Philadelphia ranks among the most diverse cities in the country. Further, it is vitally important to have managers that embody these positive mission statements but push the library towards the goals of the new strategic vision. From interviewing Jamie Wilson, Chief of Materials Management at the Free Library, it shows that he is an appropriate and pragmatic manager. There were hints throughout the interview that he is not necessarily a risk-taker and sticks with the status-quo, maybe at a fault. When reflecting on the transition that the library has gone through in the past few years, his words about the transition were positive. He seemed happy that there were new ideas flowing in and that the past ways that the library was being managed was changing. Not every manager has to be the person coming up with all of the ideas promoting change, but having a manager that is open to listening to ideas and open to change is quite important. Potentially, if the library did not effectively replace the majority of its management during the pandemic, Jamie would have been complacent and not questioned some of the processes that were happening. Currently, it seems that he is very well respected and is a team-player with his colleagues and those underneath him.

Appendix

A: Executive Staff Layout of the Free Library of Philadelphia (*Executive Staff*, n.d.).

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